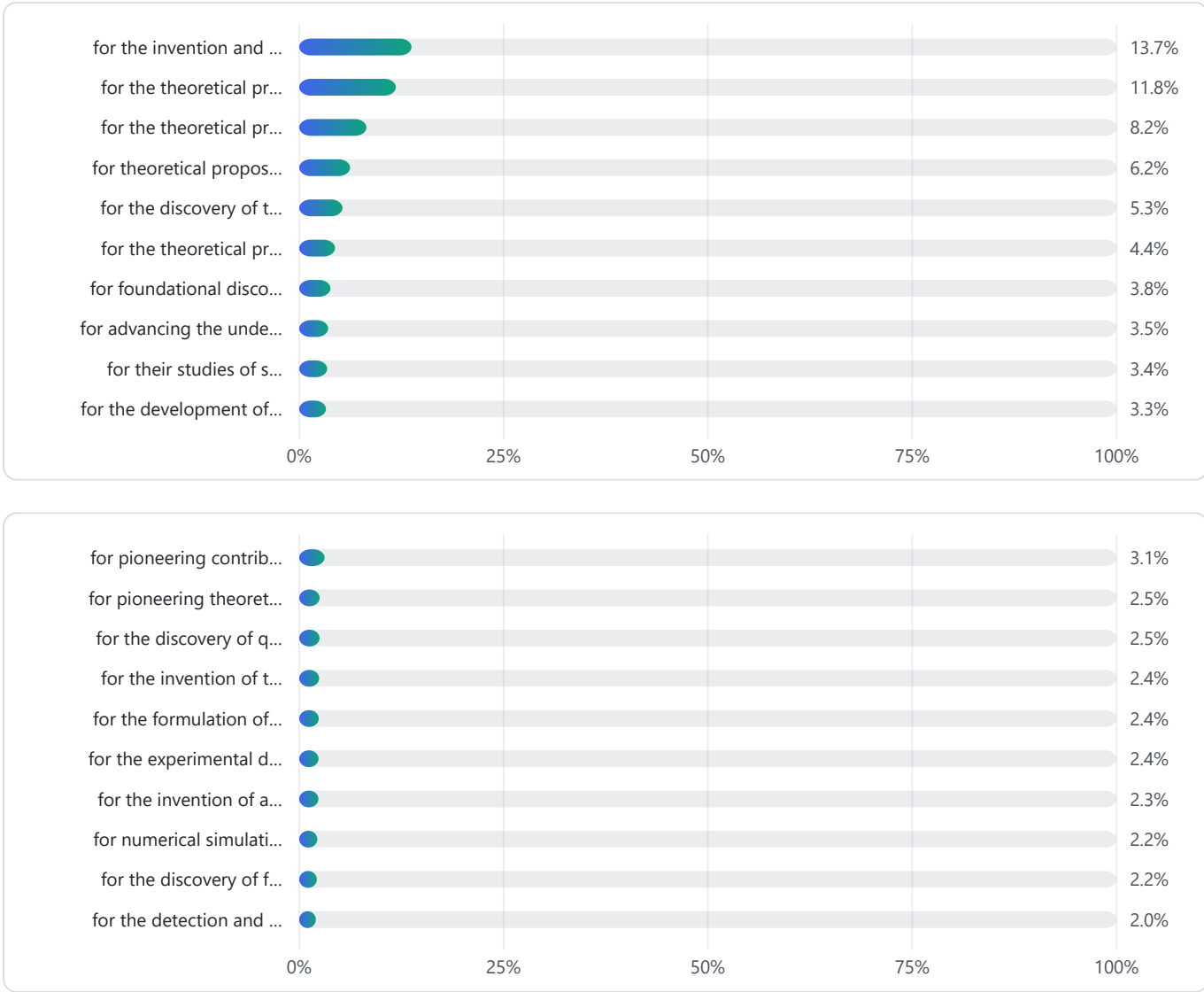


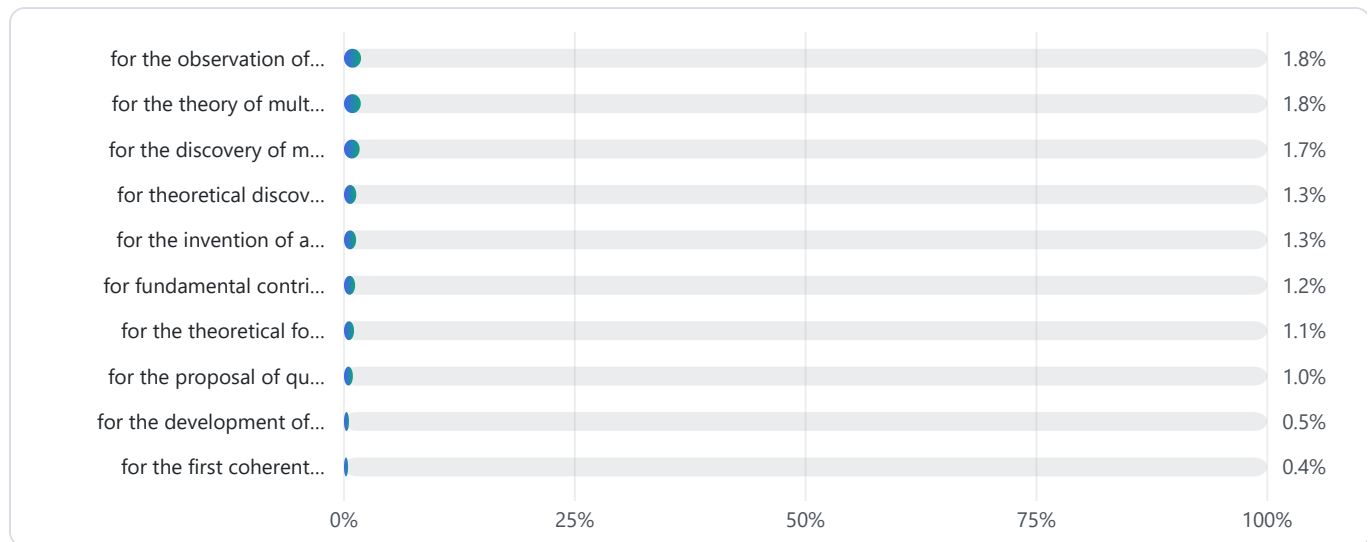


Which discovery will the 2026 Nobel Prize in Physics be awarded for?

Generated 2026년 10월 5일 오후 8:46

Forecast distribution





Full option labels

1. for the invention and development of optical lattice clocks, enabling time and frequency measurements at unprecedented precision — Jun Ye, Hidetoshi Katori
2. for the theoretical prediction and experimental realization of negative index metamaterials — John B. Pendry, David R. Smith, Eli Yablonovitch
3. for the theoretical prediction and experimental discovery of topological insulators and the quantum spin Hall effect — Eugene J. Mele, Charles L. Kane, Laurens W. Molenkamp
4. for theoretical proposals and experimental realizations of quantum simulators using ultracold atoms in optical lattices — Immanuel Bloch, J. Ignacio Cirac, Peter Zoller
5. for the discovery of topological and geometric phases in quantum systems — Michael V. Berry, Yakir Aharonov
6. for the theoretical prediction and experimental discovery of correlated insulator behavior and superconductivity in magic-angle twisted bilayer graphene — Pablo Jarillo-Herrero, Allan H. MacDonald, Rafi Bistritzer
7. for foundational discoveries in quantum information science, including quantum cryptography and quantum algorithms — Charles H. Bennett, Gilles Brassard, Peter W. Shor
8. for advancing the understanding of the surprising properties of two-dimensional electron systems in strong magnetic fields — Mordehai Heiblum, Jainendra K. Jain, James P. Eisenstein
9. for their studies of stellar explosions and the origin of the elements — Ken'ichi Nomoto, Stanford Woosley
10. for the development of highly efficient organic light-emitting diodes based on phosphorescent and thermally activated delayed fluorescence emitters — Chihaya Adachi, Mark E. Thompson, Stephen R. Forrest
11. for pioneering contributions to neutrino astronomy, in particular the discovery of high-energy cosmic neutrinos — Francis Halzen, Albrecht Karle, Naoko Kurahashi Neilson
12. for pioneering theoretical studies of fluctuations in the cosmic microwave background — George Efstathiou, John Richard Bond
13. for the discovery of quantum error correction and fault-tolerant quantum computation — John Preskill, Peter W. Shor, Alexei Y. Kitaev

14. for the invention of the quantum cascade laser — Federico Capasso, Alfred Y. Cho, Jérôme Faist
15. for the formulation of the hydrodynamic theories of active matter and flocking — John Toner, Sriram Ramaswamy, Yuhai Tu
16. for the experimental discovery of the quantum anomalous Hall effect — Qikun Xue
17. for the invention of aberration-corrected electron optics, enabling electron microscopy with sub-ångström resolution — Maximilian Haider, Knut Urban, Ondrej L. Krivanek
18. for numerical simulations that established the cold dark matter model of the formation of cosmic structure — Simon White, Carlos Frenk, Marc Davis
19. for the discovery of fluctuation theorems and exact nonequilibrium work relations that extend thermodynamics to small systems far from equilibrium — Christopher Jarzynski, Denis J. Evans, Gavin E. Crooks
20. for the detection and theoretical study of the atmospheres of exoplanets through their transits — David Charbonneau, Sara Seager
21. for the observation of the shadow of a black hole by event-horizon-scale radio interferometry — Heino Falcke, Sheperd S. Doeleman, Katherine L. Bouman
22. for the theory of multiferroic materials, in which magnetic and ferroelectric order coexist — Nicola A. Spaldin
23. for the discovery of magnetic skyrmion lattices and topological spin textures in chiral magnets — Christian Pfleiderer, Yoshinori Tokura, Naoto Nagaosa
24. for theoretical discoveries of quantum spin liquids and exactly solvable models of topological order — Alexei Y. Kitaev, Patrick A. Lee
25. for the invention of atomic force microscopy — Christoph Gerber, Gerd Binnig
26. for fundamental contributions to high-energy astrophysics, galaxies and structure formation, and cosmology — Martin Rees
27. for the theoretical formulation of cosmic inflation and the prediction of the quantum origin of cosmological structure — Alan H. Guth, Andrei Linde, Viatcheslav Mukhanov
28. for the proposal of quantum computation with electron spins in semiconductor quantum dots — Daniel Loss, David DiVincenzo
29. for the development of wavelet theory and multiresolution signal analysis — Yves Meyer, Stéphane Mallat, Ingrid Daubechies
30. for the first coherent control of a superconducting quantum bit — Yasunobu Nakamura

TL;DR

Optical lattice clocks leads my conditional forecast at 14%, supported by a mature experimental record and an exact discovery-level prize citation. Negative-index metamaterials receives 12%, followed by topological insulators and the quantum spin Hall effect at 8%, supported respectively by current institutional attention and established scientific recognition. These probabilities apply only if the winning discovery matches a listed option, under the client's resolution rules.

Context

The Physics Nobel is scheduled for October 6, 2026, at 11:45 CEST at the earliest, equivalent to 09:45 UTC. This is a pre-announcement forecast using evidence public before the question was submitted. The Academy makes the final selection; current nominations and assessments remain confidential for fifty years (official schedule, selection process).

The forecast follows the client's discovery-based rules. The named researchers need not match the laureates. A divided prize is assigned by share and announcement order, and the most specific matching option takes precedence. An unlisted discovery produces annulment, not an “Other” outcome. The probabilities therefore describe a conditional distribution, not the complete universe of possible Physics Nobel awards.

Evidence

The historical backbone argues against rigid field rotation. The complete ten-award comparison window below covers 2016–2025 and uses official motivations. Astronomy won in consecutive years, while optical techniques and quantum phenomena recur. I use this history to distinguish closely overlapping discoveries, not to declare that an entire field has become ineligible (Nobel archive).

Award year	Recognized discovery, summarized
2016	Topological transitions and phases of matter
2017	LIGO and gravitational-wave observation
2018	Optical tweezers and high-intensity ultrashort laser pulses
2019	Physical cosmology and discovery of an exoplanet around a solar-type star
2020	Black-hole formation theory and the compact object at our galaxy’s centre
2021	Climate modelling and disorder and fluctuations in physical systems
2022	Entangled-photon experiments, Bell inequalities and quantum information
2023	Attosecond light-pulse methods
2024	Discoveries enabling artificial-neural-network machine learning
2025	Macroscopic quantum tunnelling and energy quantization in electrical circuits

My inference is that another superconducting-circuit milestone deserves a larger overlap penalty than optical clocks or atom-based simulation. Likewise, the earlier topology award creates competition for topological-material discoveries without exhausting them. The history does not support a blanket exclusion of quantum information or astronomy (2025 motivation, 2016 motivation).

Symposia provide useful analogues, but not a calibrated annual win rate. Graphene and attosecond science had symposia in their Nobel years. Those examples establish that a symposium can precede recognition; they do not establish that every symposium is a shortlist. The Foundation describes these meetings as forums for fields undergoing scientific breakthroughs (symposium archive, Foundation description). I rejected calculations that mix eventual awards, same-year awards and retrospective topic matches as direct probabilities for this announcement.

Optical lattice clocks has the cleanest discovery-to-motivation fit. The Breakthrough award explicitly recognized Katori and Ye's invention and development of the optical lattice clock. Although styled the 2022 prize, it was announced on September 9, 2021. That is established recognition, not a fresh annual prediction (Breakthrough announcement). The current metrology case is strong: the BIPM's September 2026 update says optical standards outperform the current primary realization of the second, while placing a proposed optical redefinition before the 2030 General Conference. The second has not already been redefined. I read this as evidence of scientific maturity, with a remaining reason for the Nobel committee to wait (BIPM update).

The fresh Wolf signal supports both clocks and simulation. The Wolf Foundation announced the joint recognition of Ye and Bloch on October 1, 2026; Colorado reported it the next day, and NIST published its account on October 5. The citation concerns control of ultracold atomic systems, not clocks alone. I therefore split its evidential value between the clock and optical-lattice-simulation options rather than counting it twice as narrowly targeted recognition (Colorado announcement, NIST account).

Negative-index metamaterials remains a close second. Pendry's Kyoto recognition describes the theoretical design framework and subsequent experimental realization of negative-index materials. That supplies a mature theory-and-experiment case (Kyoto citation). The metamaterials Nobel Symposium ran from June 29 to July 1, 2026, with Pendry and Smith among the invited speakers. The university announced participation by the entire Physics Committee, and subsequent accounts document the meeting (university announcement, organizer's report). This warrants a year-specific premium, but the premium is smaller after auditing what committee attendance actually signifies.

Topological insulators combines foundational theory, experimental realization and direct recognition. The Breakthrough citation identifies the prediction of materials conducting at their

boundaries while insulating internally. I distinguish that discovery from the broader theoretical topological-matter contribution already recognized by the Nobel. Its remaining weaknesses are conceptual proximity and the difficulty of compressing a large contribution chain into a prize allocation—not a requirement that the option’s exact trio win (Breakthrough citation, earlier Nobel motivation).

Several alternatives retain substantial weight. The 2026 Kavli Nanoscience citation explicitly discusses the magic-angle graphene theory and the correlated insulating and superconducting discoveries. The 2025 Wolf recognition closely matches the strong-field two-dimensional-electron option. These are discovery-specific endorsements, though neither determines this year’s Nobel choice (Kavli citation, Wolf account). For quantum-information foundations, the Turing recognition announced on March 18, 2026 strengthens the standing of Bennett and Brassard. Experimental error suppression below the surface-code threshold also strengthens the practical case for error correction. I keep foundations and error correction separate because the resolution rules prefer a specific error-correction motivation (NSF announcement, primary experimental paper).

Astronomy is not merely a residual category. The Gruber recognition announced on May 19, 2026 supports the stellar-explosion and element-origin programme. Exoplanet atmospheres and CMB theory also have closely matched Kavli and Shaw recognition. These signals keep their probabilities material without relying on the claim that astronomy is “due” (Gruber announcement, Kavli astrophysics citation, Shaw citation).

The remaining evidence broadens the tail. Clarivate’s September 17, 2026 selections support OLEDs, multiferroics and quantum anomalous Hall research, but Clarivate explicitly says it does not predict recipients in a particular year. Aberration-corrected microscopy has direct Kavli recognition. Statistical physics also deserves positive weight: the current committee includes complex-systems specialist Bernhard Mehlig, whose research includes active matter. I give that a modest adjustment, not a discovery-specific endorsement (Clarivate selections, programme caveat, microscopy citation, committee roster, Mehlig’s research).

The numerical construction is judgmental, not a fitted model of confidential committee decisions. I synthesized relative strengths for scientific importance, empirical maturity, discovery-specific recognition, prior-prize overlap and current institutional attention. Correlated awards and repeated coverage were not treated as independent likelihood multipliers. I then normalized the audited scores and allocated a three-percent uniform uncertainty component across the listed options:

$$p_i = 0.97 \frac{s_i}{\sum_j s_j} + \frac{0.03}{30}.$$

$$p_i = 0.97 \sum_j s_j s_i + 300.03.$$

Here, s_i is the audited relative-strength score for discovery i , and p_i is its conditional probability. The uniform component protects against overlooked evidence and scoring errors. The final probabilities were calculated and rounded by largest remainders so their decimal sum is exactly one. Their numerical precision preserves the allocation; it does not imply comparable certainty about the committee's choice.

What's non-obvious

Committee participation is not an independent shortlist signal. The Academy's application form already instructs symposium organizers to invite members of the Programme Committee and Nobel Committees. Attendance still gives the committee direct exposure to a field, but it should not be multiplied by the symposium's topical relevance as if it were a separate endorsement. This finding is the main reason I limit the metamaterials premium (official application form).

The resolution wording also changes the ranking. The symposium covered broad wave engineering, including researchers associated with metasurfaces and other metamaterial technologies. A prize solely for one of those neighbouring discoveries would not automatically match negative-index realization. Conversely, a different laureate allocation would not invalidate a genuine discovery match. The quantum-computing symposium is another timing trap: it is scheduled for October 25–30, after the Nobel announcement, so it is not a completed pre-selection meeting (metamaterials programme, quantum symposium dates).

Uncertainties

The decisive missing evidence is the committee's actual recommendation and scientific assessment. Public prizes identify Nobel-grade work; they do not reveal the final ballot. I found no verified pre-announcement information establishing the selected discovery. That absence is not evidence against any candidate, and the confidentiality rules prevent a clean public candidate-level base rate (selection and confidentiality rules).

The ordering is sensitive to reasonable judgments about symposium relevance, recognition and discovery matching. Halving or doubling the clock score moves its probability from roughly seven to twenty-four percent; the corresponding metamaterials range is roughly six to twenty-one percent. These are model sensitivities, not statistical confidence intervals. The useful conclusion is a narrow clock lead, a strong metamaterials alternative, and a broad distribution across the remaining discoveries—not a claim that the winner has been identified.

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Question Details

The 2026 Nobel Prize in Physics is scheduled to be announced on Tuesday 6 October 2026. Each option names a discovery and the people most closely associated with it. The forecast is conditional on the prize going to one of the listed discoveries; there is no "Other" option.

Resolution Criteria

Resolves to the option whose discovery matches the discovery named in the official motivation of the 2026 Nobel Prize in Physics, as published at nobelprize.org. Options are matched by discovery; the people named in an option need not match the laureates exactly. If the prize is

divided between two discoveries, only the discovery with the larger share counts; if the shares are equal, the discovery named first in the announcement counts. If more than one option matches, the option that names the awarded discovery most specifically counts. If no option matches that discovery, the question is annulled (the forecast is conditional on one of the listed discoveries).